

any more than any other reason. In 1984 in the State of Washington, Lummi Indians inflicted some ritual bites on a 16 year old girl, a few bites that would heal completely, as part of a religious ceremony. They were charged with assault and convicted.

Circumcision never heals throughout life. The foreskin is permanently amputated, but mohels (Jewish ritual circumcisers) are allowed to continue, while American Natives with equally valid religious beliefs are punished for assault.

Genesis 17 demands that every manchild be circumcised. This is the reason Jews, Muslims, and some Christians believe they must circumcise.

Genesis 17 is not a sufficient reason to allow a helpless baby to be surgically altered for life, in a country that claims to be civilized. Literal adherence to religious scripture and ecclesiastical authority has long been humanity's worst stumbling block. It has given us the persecution of Galileo by the Roman Inquisition, the Spanish Inquisition, the New England witch hunts, and the Nazi Holocaust for 6 million Jews (Hitler was a fundamentalist religious fanatic too).

Fundamentalists of any faith who will surgically alter a child for life on the basis of Genesis 17 are no different from the Cardinals of the Roman Inquisition, Thomas de Torquemada of the Spanish Inquisition, or Adolf Hitler.

A child marked by irreversible surgery as a religious sign without consent is deprived of religious freedom.

In Christianity, the Apostle Paul states repeatedly and emphatically that circumcision is not necessary for one to be of the body of Christ (see I Cor 7:18, Gal 5:2, Gal 6:12, Phil 3:3, Col 2:11).

There is a major world religion which places a positive value on being physically whole and intact. It is Buddhism. Buddhist scripture lists 32 signs of a Holy Buddha, Enlightened One. The tenth reads, "His privates are sheathed," some translations say, "His male organ is fully retractable," or "well retracted."

Buddhism consistently emphasizes compassion, and asks followers to practice harmlessness and to avoid extremes of asceticism or self mortification. From this it is clear the early recorders of Buddhist teachings knew about the cruel rite of circumcision and wanted to emphasize that it must never be inflicted on one who would become a Buddha. This means everyone, because in Buddhism the opportunity to become a Buddha is open to every living being who chooses to follow the eightfold path of enlightenment.

A man circumcised near birth is deprived of his freedom to choose, should he desire to fully enter into the way of Buddhism. A man who is intact on the other hand is still completely free to choose for himself to be circumcised if he wants to join or to confirm faith as a Jew or a Muslim.

The fundamental issue of circumcision, religious or secular, is every human being has a *right to choose*.

***Respect child rights!***

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